

Cognition Executive Competency Framework

A competency assessment for executive roles at Cognition Labs, informed by Founders Fund's investment thesis, Silicon Valley best practices, and Cognition-specific culture signals.

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Context

Cognition Labs (makers of Devin, the autonomous AI software engineer) is a Founders Fund-backed company valued at \$10.2B with ~\$150M+ combined ARR. The company embodies an extreme performance culture: 80+ hour weeks, 6 days in-office, and 21 of its first 35 employees are former founders. This framework maps the competencies they would prioritise in an executive hire, drawing on:

- Founders Fund's 7 'House Style' principles (counterposition, avoid mimicry, outlier founders, cerebral competitiveness, hire young and groom, process-light/content-heavy, concentrate maniacally)
- Scott Wu's public statements on hiring, culture, and what drives Cognition
- Silicon Valley executive hiring best practices from a16z, Bain, and growth-stage frameworks
- Cognition's actual job postings and enterprise GTM trajectory

Ranked Competency Table

Ranked 1 (critical / non-negotiable) to 10 (nice to have). Each competency is mapped to the relevant Founders Fund principle and the specific Cognition signal that elevates its importance.

Rank	Competency	Founders Fund Principle	Cognition Signal	Description
1	Founder Mentality / Builder DNA	Seek outlier founders	21 of 35 employees are ex-founders	Acts like an owner, not a manager. Builds from zero. Takes accountability without being asked. Will do three jobs at once.
2	Intensity & Work Ethic	Concentrate maniacally	80+ hr weeks, 6 days in-office, 'we don't believe in work-life balance'	Capacity for sustained, extreme output. Not just willing - energized by the grind. This is the explicit cultural filter.
3	First-Principles / Contrarian Thinking	Counterposition; Avoid mimicry	IOI gold medalist founders; anti-playbook culture	Can invert conventional wisdom. Doesn't copy playbooks - designs new ones. Thiel's question: 'What truth do few agree with you on?'
4	Technical Fluency (AI / Product)	Process-light, content-heavy	Devin's 3-layer architecture; Kevin-32B model; DeepWiki	Can credibly discuss AI architectures, agent workflows, and the sync/async paradigm with engineering-minded buyers. Not a tourist.
5	Enterprise Sales Execution	Execution is table stakes	Goldman, Citi, Dell, Cisco as customers; \$150M+ ARR	Proven track record closing 7-figure deals with complex, multi-stakeholder procurement. Can build pipeline from zero.
6	Cerebral Competitiveness	Select for cerebral competitiveness	Engineering interview = build your own Devin in 8 hours	Intellectually driven to win. Competes on depth of thought, not just effort. Treats business as a high-stakes intellectual game.
7	Value Translation / Storytelling	Content over process	AI must translate to 'reduce migration time by 85%'	Translates deep technical capability into quantified business outcomes for skeptical CxOs in regulated industries.
8	Speed of Adaptation	Hire young, groom for leadership	Landscape changes weekly; Cursor at \$2B ARR; model labs releasing agents	Updates mental models in real-time. Comfortable with incomplete information. Half-life of knowledge here is months.
9	Category Creation / Missionary Selling	Avoid mimicry; escape competition	Devin is a new category - autonomous AI engineer, not a copilot	Educates before selling. Builds narratives around a future state buyers haven't imagined. Creates new budget lines.
10	Talent Magnetism / Network	Outlier founders attract outliers	Best executives serve as 'beacons for talent' (a16z)	Can rapidly recruit a high-performing team by tapping networks. Top candidates are available for only ~10 days.

● Ranks 1-3: Critical / Non-negotiable ● Ranks 4-6: High importance ● Ranks 7-10: Important / Nice to have

Self-Assessment Questions

Answer these candidly. The value is in honest self-assessment, not polished interview answers. Each competency will be rated 1-10 based on your responses.

1. Founder Mentality / Builder DNA [CRITICAL]

- Have you ever built a business unit, team, or function from scratch (not inherited one)? What was the starting point and what did it become?
- When was the last time you personally did work that was 'below your pay grade' because it needed to get done?
- If you joined Cognition tomorrow and had zero infrastructure, zero team, and zero pipeline - what would your first 30 days look like?

2. Intensity and Work Ethic [CRITICAL]

- What does a typical work week look like for you in terms of hours? Be honest - what's your peak sustainable intensity?
- How would your family or partner describe your relationship with work? Would they say you're energized by long hours, or that it takes a toll?
- Describe a period where you worked at an extreme level for an extended time. What drove you, and how did it end?

3. First-Principles / Contrarian Thinking [CRITICAL]

- Give an example where you held a view about your market or product strategy that most people in your organization disagreed with - and you turned out to be right.
- Peter Thiel's question: 'What truth about enterprise software sales do very few people agree with you on?'
- When was the last time you changed your mind about something fundamental in your industry? What caused the shift?

4. Technical Fluency (AI / Product) [HIGH]

- Could you explain to a CTO how Devin's architecture differs from Codex or Claude Code - covering the agent harness, sandbox environment, and async vs. sync paradigm? Rate your confidence 1-10.
- How do you currently stay current on AI/ML developments? What's the last technical concept you taught yourself?
- If a prospect's VP of Engineering challenged you on why Devin isn't just a 'wrapper around Claude', how would you respond?

5. Enterprise Sales Execution [HIGH]

- What's the largest deal you've personally closed (ACV)? Walk through the stakeholders involved and cycle time.
- Have you ever built a sales pipeline from zero in a new territory or market? What was revenue at month 6 vs. month 18?
- Describe your approach to multi-threading an enterprise deal. How many stakeholders do you typically engage, and how?

6. Cerebral Competitiveness [HIGH]

- How would you rank yourself against other enterprise sales leaders you've worked alongside - top 5%, top 25%, or somewhere else? Why?
- What do you actively do to sharpen your competitive edge - reading, communities, frameworks, coaching?
- Tell me about a deal you lost. What did you learn, and how did it change your approach?

7. Value Translation / Storytelling [IMPORTANT]

- Give your 60-second pitch for Devin to a skeptical CFO at an ASX-listed bank who's been burned by AI hype.
- How do you quantify ROI for a product that's creating a new category where there's no established benchmark?
- What's the difference between selling features vs. selling transformation? Give an example from your career.

8. Speed of Adaptation [IMPORTANT]

- Tell me about a time the competitive landscape shifted dramatically mid-quarter. What did you do in the first 48 hours?
- How quickly can you context-switch between strategic priorities? Give a concrete example.
- The AI coding tools market changes weekly. How would you keep your sales motion current when the product evolves faster than your pitch deck?

9. Category Creation / Missionary Selling [IMPORTANT]

- Have you ever sold a product where there was no existing budget line or established category? How did you create urgency?
- What's the difference between selling UiPath RPA (established category) vs. selling Devin (new category) in your mind?
- How would you handle a prospect who says 'We'll wait 12 months until this technology matures'?

10. Talent Magnetism / Network [NICE TO HAVE]

- If Cognition asked you to build an ANZ/APAC enterprise team in 90 days, how many strong candidates could you reach out to from your existing network?
- Have you ever been the reason someone joined a company - not because of the brand, but because of you?
- How do you think about building a team culture within a larger organization that has its own strong (and intense) culture?

Scoring Guide

Score	Level	Indicator
9-10	Exceptional	Best-in-class evidence. Would be a standout even at Cognition's bar.
7-8	Strong	Clear, proven evidence with specific examples. Meets the Cognition standard.
5-6	Developing	Some evidence but gaps in depth, recency, or relevance. Addressable with preparation.
3-4	Emerging	Limited evidence. Requires significant development or reframing before interview.
1-2	Gap	No meaningful evidence. Potential risk area that needs a mitigation strategy.

Sources

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